fissures of the Yatra—with ‘Jai Sri Ram’ as its rallying cry—and what it meant for India were being felt in our household.

My grandfather was a Punjabi refugee from what is now Pakistan’s Toba Tek Singh district. Most of the family had made it alive to this side of the border in 1947, but Partition, and its Hindu–Muslim killings, left a deep psychological scar. One of his brothers joined the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) when they reached Delhi, although we seldom spoke of it at home. My grandfather, a defence ministry civil servant, never joined the Sangh. But the bloody flight from his beloved village of Kamalia near Faisalabad in Pakistani Punjab and the painful rebuilding of a new life from nothing in Delhi left in him a gaping, lifelong wound and a distrust of Muslims. It made him deeply sympathetic to Hindu nationalist causes. My father, born in Nehru’s India, a year after Gandhi was assassinated, became an unapologetic Nehruvian secularist. When he joined the Indian Army, it still had a recruitment rule that denied entry to known RSS members on security-clearance grounds.[3]

The ‘Jai Sri Ram’ sticker ignited an argument in which neither side could understand the other. My father saw it as a political statement—one that he, as a serving Army officer, refused to make. My grandfather framed the issue as one of religious belief. When my father pulled the sticker off, insisting that he could not be seen driving a vehicle with religious messaging on it, my grandfather’s religiosity was deeply offended. ‘How can you remove Ram?’ he shouted. Matters were getting out of hand when my grandmother stepped in and said quietly: ‘Stop the political talk. No politics in the house. We have lost too many people to it already.’ And that was that. Or my memory of it.

It was my first personal experience of politics, an early baptism in the wider debate on Hinduness, Indianness, secularism—the complex meanings underpinning the interface of religious identity and politics that the Rath Yatra had set off. Many Indians went through versions of this same family debate as it replayed in multiple family WhatsApp groups, in drawing rooms and in discussions with friends on 5 August 2020. On this day, Prime Minister Narendra Modi presided over the consecration of the new Ram Temple, which the Supreme Court had ruled could be built on the site of the demolished